

Khanh Duong (Kevin)

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Research interests: [Intergenerational Mobility](#) [Social Norms](#) [Causal Inference](#)

For all publications, the associated data and code are made openly available on [GitHub](#) or [Figshare](#).

Education

Maastricht University, the Netherlands (with external fellowship)

Sep 2024 – Sep 2026

PhD in Economics

- Supervisors: Prof. Wim Groot (Maastricht) and Prof. Kristof De Witte (KU Leuven)
- External fellowship with [United Nations University–MERIT](#)
- Dissertation: “The role of family relationships in intergenerational inequality in education”
- Completed PhD within 2 years, including public defence (see [my reflection](#))
- Interdisciplinary: Economics (main), Sociology, Political Philosophy, Behaviour Genetics
- Approaches: Twin design, adoption design, IV reforms, causal machine learning
- Operationalized the philosophical concept of ‘Familial Relationship Goods’
- Developed a method correcting gene–environment interplay bias (rGE and GxE)

University of Turku, Finland (with employment)

Jan 2026 – Expected 2027

PhD Inequalities, Interventions and New Welfare State (DPINVEST)

- Supervisors: Prof. Jani Erola, Dr. Hannu Lehti
- Dissertation: “The paradox of meritocracy: efforts, norms, and gender”
- Employed by [INVEST Research Flagship Centre](#)
- DPInvest is my second (separate from Maastricht) with institutional approval
- Interdisciplinary: Sociology (main), Psychology, Economics

Maynooth University, Ireland (with grant)

Sep 2021 – Sep 2023

Master by Research (M.Litt) in Sociology

- Supervisors: Dr. Eoin Flaherty, Prof. Seán Ó Riain
- Fully funded by the Irish Research Council under award number [GOIPG/2021/441](#)
- Thesis: [The Roles of Poverty and Inequality as Factors in the Impact of Climate Change](#)
- Publication in [Economic Change and Restructuring](#)

Foreign Trade University, HCMC Campus, Vietnam

Sep 2012 – Apr 2016

Bachelor of International Business Economics

- GPA of 81.1%, high marks in Advanced Mathematics and Business Analytics
- Thesis: The impact of trade openness on the unemployment rate in Vietnam
- Third Prize at the HCM City–level Competition on Effective University Learning Methods

Honors and awards

Research Fellowship

Sep 2024

United Nations University–MERIT, Maastricht, Netherlands

- Project: Advancing the study of socio–economic inequality: A new analytical approach
- Supervisors: Prof. Wim Groot (Maastricht University) and Prof. Kristof De Witte (KU Leuven)

Government of Ireland Postgraduate Research Scholarship

Sep 2021

Irish Research Council, Ireland

- Project: The impact of globalization on the unemployment rate in the Asia–Pacific region
- Funding amount: €55,000.00 for two years of master’s degree

Homeworks Summer Climate Action Residency

Jun 2023

Community Climate Action Programme

- Hosted by The Common Knowledge Centre in The Burren, County Clare, Ireland
- Co–created a toolkit designed to facilitate climate action at the household level.

Selected presentations

[ECSR-CA-NASP](#) [🔗](#) Joint Spring School at Collegio Carlo Alberto

Turin, Italy

What Should Perfect Mobility Look Like?

Mar 2026

- Discussant: Prof. Fabrizio Bernardi (UNED, Madrid)
- Highly selected via a competitive international application process

[INVEST Conference 2026](#) [🔗](#) at the University of Turku

Turku, Finland

Measuring Norm Strength: The Specificity of Fairness

May 2026

- Chair: Dr. Patricia McMullin (INVEST)
- Recently published in [Acta Psychologica](#) [🔗](#)

Selected publications

- Duong, K. (2026). Measuring norm strength: The specificity of fairness under meritocracy in europe [Operationalize norm specificity (conceptual innovation) and use Hierarchical MDS (methodological adaption), see [my reflection](#) [🔗](#)]. *Acta Psychologica*, 266, 106859.
- Duong, K. (2025). If inequality is an economic choice, what is the relationship between inequality and growth? [Conceptualize inevitable inequality and employ multiobjective optimization algorithms in operations research, see [my reflection](#) [🔗](#)]. *Structural Change and Economic Dynamics*, 74(2025), 116–128.
- Duong, K. (2024). Is meritocracy just? new evidence from boolean analysis and machine learning [Novel approach with true-false logic (in philosophy) and causal machine learning]. *Journal of Computational Social Science*, 7(2), 1795–1821.
- Duong, K. (2024). What really matters for global intergenerational mobility? [Media coverage by [EurekAlert](#) [🔗](#) and [Mirage News](#) [🔗](#)]. *PLOS ONE*, 19(6), e0302173.
- Duong, K., & Flaherty, E. (2023). Does growth reduce poverty? the mediating role of carbon emissions and income inequality [Based on my research master's thesis using generalized method of moments]. *Economic Change and Restructuring*, 56(5), 3309–3334.
- Nguyen, D. P., Vo, X. V., Nguyen, V. C., Mai, X. D., & Duong, Q. K. (2021). Sustainable development for vietnam's economy in the context of globalization and industrial revolution 4.0. In *Sustainability and environmental decision making* (pp. 281–310). Springer Singapore.

Working papers

- What makes a family a family? The inevitable inequality in intergenerational educational transmission (*with Prof. Wim Groot and Prof. Kristof De Witte*). [In Doctoral dissertation, Chaps. 2–3].
- What should perfect mobility look like? Fair progress in the intergenerational mobility in education (*with Prof. Wim Groot and Prof. Kristof De Witte*). [In Doctoral dissertation, Chap. 4].
- The price of protecting family relationships for educational mobility (*with Prof. Wim Groot and Prof. Kristof De Witte*). [In Doctoral dissertation, Chap. 5].
- Gender-equality paradox under meritocracy: Measuring gender specialization across societies (*with Prof. Jani Erola and Dr. Hannu Lehti*). [Norm specificity to explain the relationship between meritocracy and gender paradox].

Research skills

Programming skills: L^AT_EX, Markdown, Word-Excel-PowerPoint, Quarto, Jupyter, CRAN-R, Stata, Python, SPSS, GitHub, WordPress, Blogger.

Experience with Datasets: European Social Survey (ESS), World Values Survey (WVS), Cross-National Online Survey (CRONOS), World Bank Open Data (WDI), Global Database on Intergenerational Mobility (GDIM), International Social Survey Programme (ISSP)

Quantitative methods: Randomized Controlled Trial (RCT), Difference-in-Difference (DiD), Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD), Sample Selection (Heckman), Instrumental Variables (IV), Time-Series Analysis, Panel Data Analysis, Structural Equation Modelling (SEM), Causal Machine Learning, Generalized Random Forests, Social Network Analysis, Textual Analysis, and Microsimulation.

Soft skills: Funding application, Time management, Project management, Teamwork, Critical thinking, [Academic writing](#) [🔗](#), Philosophical reasoning, and Self-learning.

Languages: Vietnamese: Native; English: C1 (equivalent); German: beginner, Finnish: beginner

Scholarly participation

Peer-review: Economic Change and Restructuring; Economics of Innovation and New Technology; Social Science Quarterly; Environment, Development and Sustainability; PLOS ONE; Humanities and Social Sciences Communications; Applied Research in Quality of Life; Structural Change and Economic Dynamics

Academic membership: Society for the Advancement of Socioeconomics; Maynooth University Social Science Institute; European Consortium for Sociological Research

Referees

Prof. Wim Groot, Professor of Health Economics and Evidence-Based Education
Maastricht University and UNU-MERIT, ✉ w.groot@maastrichtuniversity.nl

Prof. Kristof De Witte, Vice-Dean and Professor of Education Economics and Political Economy
Faculty of Economics and Business, KU Leuven, ✉ kristof.dewitte@kuleuven.be

Prof. Jani Erola, Academy Professor in Sociology, Director of INVEST Research Flagship Centre
Faculty of Social Science, University of Turku, ✉ jani.erola@utu.fi

Dr. Hannu Lehti, Academy Research Fellow in Sociology, INVEST Research Flagship Centre
Faculty of Social Science, University of Turku, ✉ hpleht@utu.fi